Begin the work.

Begin, Begun, and Begin, again.

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Overview

These books will help you begin, and finish what you've begun, so you can begin, again.

Begin,
Begun,
Begin, again,

Call it a mantra, a framework, a philosophy, and a practice, because the hardest part of any great work is the beginning.

Why is it so hard to begin, part of the difficulty must be in the time that we are in. We are living in the tween years of the digital age – 12 years after the launch of the iPhone which singlehandedly changed the landscape of societal, interpersonal, governmental, and individual relationship and norms. With this disruption, we now face monumental problems – some predicted, some self-inflicted and others not foreseen, but only by the most clairvoyant. Ahem, 1984. Individuals are trying to cope with the glut of information and feedback available to them; communities are trying to build new norms around the digital influx into all spaces and places; businesses are pushing customers to the edge of the unhealthy consumerism; and Governments around the world continue to be overwhelmed with the new digital realities and much needed regulation is slow because those in power lack understanding of the issues in play.

This is a season of digital puberty, where early adopters find themselves way ahead of the norm, able to traverse the pitfalls of entrepreneurship in the digital age, making billions in the process. These "unicorns" may have set the trend but as the rest of us take on the work of digital transformation in our context, we have an opportunity implement solutions for a holistic growth without the excesses of our trendsetting idols. I am writing this book, because we need full participation in creating a better

world, which will only happen through better management of projects, products and ideas. Culling the failures before we invest millions of investment capital into the idea. Failing forward fast, iterative building of micro-solutions, pivots and small launches into an ultimate success. Remote work teams that value productivity over process or hours in a seat.

We have to be the ones to begin this work. You and me.

So far, I've given a glimpse into the macro problems this book tries to solve and below is a quick overview of the micro problems this book will address.

In the last 15 years of work across many different industries I've found two types of teams stalled in progress:

1. Individuals, businesses, and institutions stuck in a standstill, entrenched in legacy systems, processes, and people unable to reinvent themselves.
2. Others are stuck in analysis paralysis, sitting on loads of cash but overwhelmed with the options available -- unable to choose the right project to invest in.

My goal for this three-book set is to unlock these two types of personas from their stagnation -- motivating them to launch their next big thing utilizing the Begin, Begun, Begin, again framework.

This three-book set is broken down as follows:

Book 1: Begin.

In the first book we look at the what and the why. First aligning our idea to a broader context and tangible goals. The work done to understand and set up the context is the backbone of any idea that has a chance of succeeding. Many people fail because they ignore the foundational step of contextualization and goal setting. Ignoring the what and the why is to begin without an origin story, to start without direction.

Book 2: Begun.

Once you've got a back story – the what and the why – you can begin the work of building out the how. This second book's goal is to introduce a framework, in the form of four lessons, taking an idea from a concept to a launched thing. This flexible framework turns obstacles into opportunities or pivot points, with an emphasis on how to discipline our teams to consistently do the damn work.

Book 3: Begin, again.

The final book in the series looks to what happens after you've launched or failed to launch. In the aftermath of failure or success the next step is very simple – you must begin, again. The layout of this final book is three-paths:

1. Iterative delivery – the art of continuous improvement with small upgrades.
2. Fail Forward Fast – how to quickly move past the failures you will experience.
3. Begin again – Unlock dreams beyond the initial idea… simply, what is next?

These three distinct books will help the reader begin, and finish what they've begun, so they can begin, again. In the formulation of the what and the why, we begin our climb through the content with the right footing, placed in the right context. Once we've begun the work, we will turn obstacles into launching opportunities motivating our team focus on the work. Finally, in the aftermath, we habituate the process by beginning again. This three-book set enables organizations to grow out of the awkwardness of digital pubescence and into mature functional organizations capable of continuous improvement and delivery. This style of work, successfully demonstrated by many teams in Silicon Valley, is needed inside all organizations, non-profits, small businesses, and government entities alike – everyone needs to be able to Begin, Begun, and Begin, again.

Bio: Sam DuRegger

Sam has spent 15+ years in non-profit, small business, funded startups, interactive agencies, consulting, corporate organizations, and in State Government. His work includes being the Product Lead on the Bible App, which now boasts over 400M^{+} downloads on individual devices and leading the SONIC Digital Innovation team through the national launch of an omni-channel order ahead experience. This ecommerce ecosystem includes a personalized interactive experience on 80,000^{+} touch screens in 3,600^{+} stores throughout the U.S.

Sam has held leadership roles on interactive projects for the PGA, Subaru Motors, Ford, EA Sports, Starbucks, Blue Bottle Coffee, Stumptown Coffee, La Colombe Coffee, Kum & Go, Hy-Vee Grocery, Hallmark, and Mastercard.

Sam is currently contributing to the modernization effort at The State of Oklahoma as the acting Chief Procurement Officer. He is focused on the digital adaptation of legacy processes; an overhaul of the Central Purchasing Act to better suite today's digital landscape; and enhancements to citizen's digital experience with the State of Oklahoma.

Sam's focus on change management within the agile framework has led to a transformation of how organization's begin projects, structure teams, press through the messy middles, build iteratively, and ultimately learn to fail forward towards a solution.

Sam has a Bachelor's in Science from the University of Tulsa, a Master's in Theology from John Brown University and a Master's in Business Administration from The University of Oklahoma's Price College of Business.

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Market Analysis

Audience: This is geared generally toward Millennials (born between 1979 – 2000), both male and female looking to begin their next project or work. This market is looking for ways in which to contribute, to build, and to do so without expertise or experience. This is the YouTube culture that has been raised on DIY YouTube videos – they are looking for frameworks to experiment with and not prescriptive and progressive paperwork to complete. This group spends their money on experience and innovative products and services. They pull advise from peers and influencers over social networks rather than through traditional advertising and general trends. They have taken a more meandering route to their career and for that fact this book appeals to their sense of what's next and FOMO (fear of missing out) on what they should be doing with their life and career.

The Millennial comprised of 79M people contributing $0.6 Trillion of annual spend[1].

Narrowing this large demographic down to a more specific target market of Millennials who have a college degree (only around 1/3 of Millennials have a college degree[2]) and are either stuck in middle management or in small businesses controlled by boomers. They are the ones waiting in the wings, seeing what needs to be done, but having to wait till the boomers retire to get their unique perspectives heard.

Strategically, I believe we are living in an era with the most opportunity for innovation across all industries and sectors of work. Smartphone use has only begun to shift from an entertainment and consumption driven device to something more useful and production oriented. This is where we Begin the work, with intention around habitualizing ideation and embracing failure. With this mindset, I would lean into more general topics for mainstream media including – how digital transformation is effecting all sorts of industries from small retail to large enterprises and even governments – the work is before us and all we need to do is begin and not be paralyzed by how much work there is to be done.

Secondarily, there is a market for frameworks as maker's and influencers on social media are adept at taking a loosely structured concept and creating endlessly creative rebounds.[3] These influencers are looking for content to continue their platforms relevancy, and Begin, Begun, Begin, again has the potential to be magnified on through their influence and networks.

Lastly, I see the college educated millennial as a motivated and ambitious workforce waiting to contribute, but not having the green light to do so in their current line of work. The frameworks presented in Begin the work, will give them language to "sell up" innovation to their superiors, as well as a community of other builders to be encouraged and motivated by.

Or, if they cannot find the success within their current line of work, the motivation to begin their own great work – launching companies, products and services of their own. The problems our society faces in the next 10 years will need Millennials to be fully engaged with the proper toolkit to fulfill digital transformation in all aspects of our society – industrial, societal, environmental, financial, and governmental change.

I believe this book will help them begin.

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1. https://www.statista.com/topics/1780/us-millennials-shopping-behavior/
2. https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2018/03/16/how-millennials-compare-with-their-grandparents/
3. A rebound in Dribbble terms is a riff off of someone else's design to create something new or built upon the old. https://dribbble.com/shots?list=playoffs

Pre-launch Promotion

- **Begin the podcast**
  - URL – http://beginthework.com/podcast/
  - 1st Season goal of 10 episodes
  - Creatives, artists, politicians, and entrepreneurs
  - Progressive conversation on how they began their work, what problems they ran into, and what is there next project.
  - Goal — growth of social media: Twitter & Instagram @beginthework
  - Status: 7 episodes published, working on guest speaker list have a commitment from Mayor of Oklahoma City, OK, David Holt.

- **Begin the work — Speaking engagements**
  - http://beginthework.com
  - Goal — Regional awareness of the work I'm doing and my communication ability to spur individual growth and better team dynamics.
  - Status: 1M Cups, Go Win Podcast, and continually soliciting other opportunities.

Post-launch Promotion

- **Begin the podcast**
  - Season 2 - 10-20 more episodes
  - More prominent and national voices
  - Goal — Growth through other people's networks
  - Ongoing content relevance

- **Begin the work — Speaking engagements**
  - Focus on conferences
  - Merchandise to sell
  - Goal – Growth through market awareness and expert position of Sam.

- **Begin the work — Conference**
    - Regional conference to bring speakers stories to more people
    - Merchandise sales
    - Podcast opportunities
    - Goal — Growth through brand awareness (not just Sam awareness)

- **Begin the Adwords — Social Media Strategy**
    - Google Adwords
        - Comparable books ad campaign
        - Entrepreneurial ad campaign
        - Demographic ad campaign
            - 16 - 36yr old — 20years span
            - 16-26 — Go-getter, know-it-all, world dominator
            - 26-30 — Looking to Pivot, need to make a change, re-focus
            - 30-36 — legacy maker, what do I pass on, how do I re-invent
    - Facebook Ads
        - see above
    - End-goal
        - Traffic - push to podcasts w/special interviews
        - Sales - push to book

Brand Influence & Experience: Over the past 12 years of digital product work, I've been utilized as a key spokesperson for the products and experiences we've launched. I've been highlighted in regional newspapers, national news syndication, influencer blog posts, and video blogs. In the launch of Order Ahead at Sonic Drive-In, I was asked to be available for any news articles and created video demos for media consumption as well as for all of the franchisees and employees implementing Order Ahead. For many, I was the face of Order Ahead at Sonic. The same can be said of my work with Alpha Dominche, a coffee startup out of Salt Lake City in 2012, and

currently with Woodshed Coffee and Tea, where I was recently highlighted in Edible OKC, and have also been mentioned in Bon Appetite online blog in 2018. When I closed down my personal twitter account in 2019, I had 2.1K followers and over 1K followers on Instagram. I closed it down to focus on my writing and growing the brands I manage on Social media and not myself, personally.

I am currently spending my time bolstering the @beginthework Instagram account with posts on creativity and Oklahoma City design and entrepreneurship scene, as well as highlighting the five episodes of the Begin the work Podcast and its guests work. I manage a few other accounts centered around ecommerce and retail businesses including @woodshedtea, @a_duregger_project, and @story_build. My total follower count on Instagram for the brands I own and manage is 2,447 as of 12/13/19.

Currently, as the State Purchasing Director of Oklahoma, I manage a large team of procurement specialists as well as oversight on the training of 850^{+} Certified Procurement Officers with monthly webinars and quarterly gatherings. As the Chief Procurement Officer for the State of Oklahoma, I have influence that spans across the 116 State Agencies and hundreds of political subdivisions throughout the State of Oklahoma. I work hand-in-hand with the COO of the State of Oklahoma and have regular meetings with the Governor updating him on digital transformation initiatives throughout our division.

I have not leveraged this network as of yet, but will be working to expand the awareness of my work in the next legislative session, as I am working with our legislators on a revamp of the Central Purchasing Act, which will require some press time, as well as a possible Op-Ed in the Oklahoman making a case for Digital Transformation in the form of Policy Reform.

I have written a few articles for magazines including, now out-of-print Collide

Magazine and have been highlighted on influencer blogs with demonstrations of products and representation of brands I've worked with.

I absolutely love speaking and have been given the opportunity to speak at a few events over the last couple years here in Oklahoma City, including keynote at The State of Oklahoma's Financial Manager's Association annual meeting, Skyline Church, and at multiple local startup/design meetings on product management and user experience. Over the next few months, my focus will be on broadening my speaking schedule, podcast reach, and follower count on the @beginthework social media accounts as mentioned in the pre-launch promotion strategy section above.

Competitive Analysis

Begin the work box set, should be broadly placed in the business category, recent comparable titles within the best sellers' lists would include, "*Thinking Fast and Slow*" by Daniel Kahnemann and "*Atomic Habits*" by James Clear, as these books have a focused thesis around getting better at something, or improving something both as an individual or an organization. Looking more closely at the category, I have chosen four books published over the last few years as a baseline for comparison. These books range from niche reads in specific sub-categories (Business: Environmentalism and Design: Philosophy) to well-regarded books with dedicated followers in the Digital Innovation/Product Management discipline.

***The Responsible Company* by Yvon Chouinard (Patagonia Books, 2012)**

This book details lessons learned from 40 years in business by Yvon Chouinard CEO of Patagonia. Yvon's first book "*Let my people go surfing*" was a philosophical treatise on why we should be more flexible, responsible and concerned for our employees, "*The Responsible Company*" goes into detail on how this was done at Patagonia, including how they've failed, pivoted, and ultimately try to succeed. I'm including this because it is tactical in nature without being prescriptive, written to business owners, aspiring entrepreneurs and executives to show what is possible if the vision of the company is directed at being responsible for the environment, the employees, the supply chain, and even the employees children. *Begin the work* adds to the conversation with a focus on constructing the why and the why of a project based on the values of the organization's leadership. Then after the values are defined and the roadmap is in place how does a team move into the how, specifically focused on digital solutions and cross-functional teams.

***Digital Adaptation* by Paul Boag (Smashing Magazine, 2014)**

This book is geared toward executives and managers trying to convince executives on the proper way to tackle Digital Adaptation of an organization. It is an amazing book for how it tackles persuasion as well as defining obstacles faced by many managers tasked with creating change in an organization. I believe it is a foundational book for

managers and executives to get on the same page as far a language and vision for digital transformation, and I believe *Begin the work* adds to the conversation with a well laid out framework to begin the work towards adaptation once everyone is on the same page in both language and vision for what is possible.

The Shape of Design **by Frank Chimero (Frank Chimero via Kickstarter, 2012)**
This short and beautifully constructed book by designer Frank Chimero places an emphasis on why design is fundamental to good storytelling, craft, and ultimately the creative process. It is more philosophical in nature and sets the dinner table with language and emphasis on the role of design. *Begin the work* is looking to become the roast and potatoes served on this beautifully constructed table. Taking the fundamentals of design philosophy and adding to it a framework to getting work done in a timely manner, with collaboration as the gravy that ties everything together.

Product Leadership **by Richard Banfield, Martin Eriksson & Nate Walkingshaw (O'Reilly Media, Inc., 2017)**
This is more of a textbook on what Product Leadership is, including an introduction to Product Management as a career path which was birthed out of the design and project management disciplines in response to a quickly changing technology industry since the advent of the iPhone in 2007. After the introduction it is structured in three parts looking at Product Management's different roles in startups, small businesses, and corporate enterprises. *Begin the work* would be the lab book if Product Leadership was taught in a class or seminar. Taking the fundamentals of Product Management into an experimental world of iterations and progress over process.

Begin the work fits snuggly between the philosophy of design and the theories of product management. Needing both of these institutions to build out a framework of work – work that has to be done, and not just spoken about. The first book in the *Begin the work* series – *Begin,* is strategically focused on taking creative energy of ideas and possibilities and honing it into something tangible. The second book –

Begun, takes the tangible thing created and progresses it towards an eventual conclusion of success or failure. Then in the last book – *Begin, Again*, I ask the builder to take a step back and reassess the situation, so that they might plunge right back into the beginning of something better or completely new.

Comparable Titles & Authors:

Product Leadership by Richard Banfield, Martin Eriksson & Nate Walkingshaw
Remote by Jason Fried & David Heinemeier Hansson
Rework by Jason Fried & David Heinemeier Hansson
The Phoenix Project by Gene Kim, Kevin Behr, & George Spafford
The Goal by Eliyahu M. Goldratt
The War of Art by Steven Pressfield
Do the work by Steven Pressfield
The Dip by Seth Godin
A Responsible Company by Yvon Chouinard

Boutique Publishing Houses & Titles:

Do Books by Do Lectures — https://thedobook.co
- Do Design by Alan Moore
- Do Disrupt by Mark Shayler
- Do Story by Bobette Buster

A Book Apart - Publisher: https://abookapart.com/
- Just Enough Research, Erika Hall
- Conversational Design, Erika Hall
- Design for Real Life, Eric Meyer & Sara Wachter-Boettcher

Smashing Books - Publisher: https://www.smashingmagazine.com/printed-books/
- Digital Adaptation by Paul Boag
- Design Systems by Alla Kholmatova
- User Experience Revolution by Paul Boag

Self-Published Titles & Authors:

The Shape of Design by Frank Chimero
The Manual by Andy McMillan

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- Path Two — You've Shipped
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Book One -- Begin

Introduction

In the book's introduction, I will explain the importance that we begin our great work -- as individuals, as teams, and within all of our organizations. I will set the macro-context for the case for continued digital transformation, as well as the micro-context for why it is important, we do not distract ourselves with consumption, and instead focus on production.

Lesson One: Life is not a marathon, life is training for a marathon.

This chapter introduces the problem of living everyday as a marathon, not allowing for nuance, rest, pivots, and variability of work. If every day is a performance, it's no wonder our workforce is burnt out.

I want the reader to take home the idea of working in an agile mindset, that you don't have to have everything planned out before you begin, that there is well proven framework to begin the work with a loose plan as long as the end goal is defined.

Insert 1: Stop Doing This

This insert includes a few short essays on what to stop doing, practical tips as one begins the work. Two to three call outs of what to absolutely stop doing!

Lesson Two: The Why before the What

Lesson 1 delivers an introduction to the idea that you don't have to have everything planned to begin the work. This lesson builds upon that idea and emphasizes the importance of a cross-functional understanding of the why before the what. Teams must be aligned on the problem, and why they are being asked to dedicate their energy and skills toward the solution.

The chapter's goal is to empower the reader to spend time in the why to know the problem and be able to articulate that problem in a way that brings other's on board.

Digital things are best built by a community of people who know what they are building and why they are building it.

Lesson Three: Beware of the False Start

This chapter is focused on the start… ensuring the reader doesn't go before the market, team, or organization is ready. False starts can be detrimental to an idea, and while there is no perfect time to begin, there are some things you can do to ensure the time is right to begin the work.

Takeaway for this chapter, will include a final checks and balances on the idea or concept. Ensuring the reader understands the why, can communicate the what and the why – and understand the market forces and readiness of the individual, team or organization. To begin right, one must be at least aware of the outside forces and potential pitfalls, only then can they launch themselves out of the block.

Insert 2: Start Doing This

This second insert is a practical call to create healthy habits as you begin the work. Two to three antidotes and applicable habits for the individual and team.

Lesson Four: Your Origin Story

How you tell your origin story is as important as how others perceive it. Digital media allows full transparency and authenticity in the progress of your business. How transparent will you be and how can you ensure your transparency matches the perception of your business.

I hope to leave the reader with knowledge that they have some control over the perception of their success. The line between authenticity and oversharing is fine and fragile, how can you best share the story as you make it.

Book Two -- Begun

Introduction

You've begun. Now what? This book lays out the difficulty ahead, and while beginning is the hardest, because momentum is hard to create, once you've begun, you'll face the challenge of carrying the momentum uphill. This is the bitter pill of riding the downhill momentum of starting something, eventually the adrenaline flatlines, and mountains materialize ahead of you. It's now time to climb.

Lesson One: There be dragons.

This chapter looks directly at the individual and speaks to the needed effort to work on yourself to become a valued member of your team. The hero's goal is to slay the dragon in the tower, but it is in the journey the hero is made. As experiences and hardship carve off the vanities and humbles the hero into their authentic self.

Are you a hero? A reliable teammate? A clutch performer? A role player? A trusted advisor? This chapter's goal is to ensure the reader is ready to work on themselves as the path they are on depends on it.

Insert 1: The Hero and the Anti-Hero

There are two types of protagonists in a novel, which will you be? The valiant do-gooder that smiles their way through the hardship or are you the curmudgeon who seems to lose every battle but ends up winning the war?

Each persona has its upside and neither persona ensures success. This chapter is focused on validating your authentic self, and not trying to be something you are not.

Lesson Two: How to see, scale, and soar off every obstacle.

This chapter will focus on how to turn obstacles into opportunities. Hint… it's a mindset, not a process. Some try to pivot when obstacles come in their way, and that may be an option. Good teams don't pivot until they fail, rather, they try to understand

what might be coming, so that when it comes they are ready to soar towards the next opportunity.

This chapter is preparing the reader for hardship and obstacles, to create a calm demeanor in the face of challenges you will face in building a product or service.

Insert 2: Fail Forward Fast

This chapter will focus tactically on failing forward fast when an obstacle is too big to launch from. How can you quickly assess the failure and pivot the team towards the next opportunity?

The end goal of this insert is to introduce "Mean Time to Recovery" a way to look at failure as a step along the way and shift focus away from the fall, moving it to the recovery and how fast you and your team can move on.

Lesson Three: Quicksand or the Messy Middles

Over the course of a project, months can go quickly and there may come a moment where you wonder if you'll ever launch. Obstacles have taken resources and time, and it seems you may be in quicksand, where every step digs you deeper instead of progressing you down the path toward deployment. Welcome to the messy middles.

Hope for this chapter is that the reader can avoid anger and frustration as they hit a slog in the middle of the project. Practical advice for how to motivate your team through the hardship of moving slowly when the market demands a quick release.

Insert 3: Framework Design 101

This insert is tactical, in that it gives the reader a glimpse into framework design -- creating paths or steps others can find and follow, avoiding the time-consuming act of creating documented processes that succeed or fail depending on adherence to said process.

Frameworks give individuals and teams boundaries to innovate within and around, while promoting progress over process.

Lesson Four: Consistency in the How

This chapter concludes the Begun book, with an encouragement toward consistency and persistency in your work. This is the chapter you re-read when you need a positive push forward! Reminding you that it is in consistent persistence that the work is done.

Some may finish with a flurry; others may get lucky… but it is the persistent that find fulfillment in their successes.

BEGIN, AGAIN

Introduction

In the book's introduction, I will review where you've come from, ensuring you recall your origin story and the obstacles you've face to get to this point. This is about enjoying the journey of building and learning from the finish.

Path One: You've Failed

Not every project is successful, some fizzle quickly, others explode monumentally, and even others die a slow tired death. This chapter focuses on how you embrace failure and move on, we've already discussed failing forward fast in development practices, now it's time to incarnate this ideal, when you're at the depths of a failed enterprise.

I want the reader to look at failure in the face, which is why it is chapter one, and not buried below the successful paths. It is the path most taken, and one must endure its unpleasantness if one is to learn from it.

Path Two: You've Shipped

This chapter is focused on celebrating the launch of a product or a delivery of the project. Take time and create space to recollect on what got you here, then you learned and re-aim your business or team towards the next big milestone.

I want the reader to not just move to the next beginning, but to celebrate, learn from the failures, pivots, and obstacles that became opportunities. It is a time to recollect before the energy is pointed in another direction.

Path Three: You've Finished

This chapter will look to the future whether you've failed or succeeded. The first two chapters were post-mortem in their approach, ensuring the individual and team took time to learn from the past. This chapter is about orienting those learnings to the future.

Success in this chapter is in tying together the whole framework of Begin, Begun, Begin, again – that life is not just one big race, but instead a series of races with variable training and seasons of rest between them. Life is learning how to finish without killing yourself, how not to die when you retire, and how to begin, again with the experience of your past powering you ahead.

We help you begin, and finish what you've begun, so you can begin, again.

Begin,
Begun,
Begin, again,

Call it a mantra, a framework, a philosophy, and a practice, because the hardest part of any great work is the beginning.

Sample Chapter from Book 1 – Begin

Lesson #1 - Life is not a marathon, life is training for a marathon.

At 35 years old, I found myself in a demanding job, working 50-60 hours a week sitting in a cubicle with little to no activity during my day. I would get home at 6:30-7pm, where dinner would be waiting plated on the counter under Reynolds wrap. I would then eat quickly and attempt to stay awake while my kids demanded books to be read, baths to be had, and games to be played.

At that time, we had three kids under the age of 5 (two of which were twins), life was full, and I was the unhealthiest I've ever been. Browsing through pictures one day on my phone I saw a picture of myself playing with my kids. I looked tired, haggard, and out-of-breath.

It was time for a change.

I had always been told, "life was a marathon." With the assumption you had to keep grinding away at the miles, until you finished the race (which presumably meant death... because if you've been around running, some of those who finish marathons look and sound like they are near death). Knowing I was unhealthy and needed a change, I called a good friend of mine, who years earlier had made a drastic lifestyle change of his own and was now coaching people to do the same. Over coffee, he began asking me about my goals and I answered the question with my normal candor...

"Well, I'm 40 pounds overweight, I have high blood pressure, and I can't play with my kids in the backyard without fear of an aneurism. So, I guess my goal is to get healthy."

He didn't necessarily like that answer, and being a coach told me point blank. "Well, that may all be well and true, but it isn't a goal."

"Ok, then I want to run a marathon."

Again, he answered patiently and with wisdom, "Well, let's first just get you moving. Let's meet again in a couple months after you can run 3 miles without stopping."

After three long months, I called him back.

"Ok, I've been running 2-3 times a week and can run 3 miles... but my times are ugly slow."

"Great," He answered, "Let's grab coffee and I'll show you what we do at Courage Running."

While sipping on coffee, he walked me through a common misconception about training for a marathon — that it's all about the miles. In his training program he focuses on getting the love of running back into your soul (and soles) with a flexible and variable training program helping your body remember how to run. We set a goal, not to run a marathon, but to run a sub-2-hour half-marathon, which looking at my current mile splits, seems near impossible. Our goal directed everything about the training plan, including splits, progress milestones, and recovery days.

This specific, measurable, and ambitious yet attainable goal drove every decision from that point forward.

Over the next four months, I followed the training as close as possible, there were moments of adulation and of utter defeat. We tweaked the training, changed the mile splits, moved the recovery days — all based on my capacity and performance in previous weeks.

I certainly made some strategic decisions and put perimeters and processes in my daily routine to ensure success. My wake up moved up an hour-and-a-half to 5:30am and my clothing of choice for morning runs moved from baggy gym shorts and a cotton shirt to spandex shorts and layered sweat wicking shirts. I didn't plan my meals for the next four months but did periodically look at my eating habits to recognize what prepared me to crush a long run (banana and peanut butter sandwich) and what would be my kryptonite (Curry and Fried Rice). I didn't just run to log miles, I sometimes had sprint workouts around a track, progressive tempo runs or pyramids, in which I ran my slowest mile first and my fastest mile last and long slow runs to increase my endurance and stamina. There was ebb and flow, conversation and compromise.

Training was difficult and yet fun, it was never monotonous, but always challenging.

Race time - Memorial Marathon, OKC

After four months of dedicated training, it was time to run my first half-marathon with a goal of breaking the 2-hour mark. The start was incredible, first off it starts at the OKC Memorial, which is a sacred place to begin with, and second I didn't anticipate the mass of people and energy. Running west into downtown is downhill, so as you begin there is a stream of runners in front of you with thousands behind you. I was already emotionally thin with the memory of the Bombing and this image just put me over the top. I cried all the way down Harvey Avenue. It was just beautiful to see so many people exerting effort, putting themselves through the pain and dedication of training to come to this place, in this moment, just to run. It was awesome.

Once I settled into the race, I manically focused on my pace and splits, knowing that in order to hit my goal time, I'd have to run around 9:00 a mile for over 13.1 miles. This focus was warranted if I was to run under 2 hours. I had no down time, no miles to slack off, no water breaks to linger, no stretches to sprint, and no time for innovation. The race was about execution of the strategy with a huge reliance on the training.

It struck me shortly after I crossed the line in 1:58:18, that life is nothing like a marathon, but it sure is a lot like training for a marathon.

Oklahoma City Memorial Marathon 2015 - Half Marathon - results OnlineRaceResults.com

PLACE	NAME	DIV	DIV PL	GUN	10K	7.6M	PACE	TIME
1301	Derek Olson	M 30-34	164/561	2:00:38	56:02	1:09:22	9:01	1:58:13
1302	Blake Compton	M 20-24	103/309	2:10:29	55:13	1:08:39	9:01	1:58:13
1303	Jennifer Medkief	F 30-34	86/1029	1:59:01	53:54	1:06:52	9:01	1:58:13
1304	Mark Humphreys	M 45-49	64/340	2:00:39	56:01	1:09:22	9:01	1:58:13
1305	Leigha Braaten	F 20-24	73/707	2:03:55	56:03	1:08:54	9:01	1:58:13
1306	Susan Planer Phillips	F 45-49	20/539	2:00:39	55:57	1:09:22	9:01	1:58:13
1307	Samantha Olson	F 25-29	113/1010	2:06:45	54:47	1:07:40	9:01	1:58:14
1308	Cole Matthews	M 40-44	91/384	1:58:40	55:14	1:08:13	9:01	1:58:14
1309	Eric Jamison	M 35-39	146/503	2:02:30	56:28	1:09:57	9:02	1:58:16
1310	Jeremy Hillis	M 30-34	165/561	2:05:48	57:41	1:10:47	9:02	1:58:16
1311	Karen Braswell	F 25-29	114/1010	1:59:55	57:34	1:10:35	9:02	1:58:16
1312	Christopher Craig	M 25-29	160/493	2:01:56	54:48	1:07:53	9:02	1:58:16
1313	Ali Dudley	F 20-24	74/707	2:02:03	53:25	1:06:37	9:02	1:58:18
1314	Sam Duregger	M 35-39	147/503	2:01:27	56:26	1:09:27	9:02	1:58:18
1315	Marcia Sauzek	F 45-49	21/539	2:01:22	54:59	1:07:48	9:02	1:58:19
1316	Heidi Zerby	F 45-49	22/539	2:01:23	54:58	1:07:48	9:02	1:58:19
1317	Jon Tucker	M 45-49	65/340	1:59:40	50:48	1:03:35	9:02	1:58:20
1318	Craig Nelson	M 30-34	166/561	2:14:17	57:21	1:10:23	9:02	1:58:20
1319	Katie Clark	F 30-34	87/1029	1:58:30	54:11	1:07:54	9:02	1:58:20

And to move the analogy closer to the point of this book — Building a product is not very much like a marathon, but it sure does feel like training for one.

Let's take some time to dig into that last statement a bit, because I want to be sure you take this piece from your mind, to your heart, to your hands — race day comes periodically and you must be prepared because it will pull everything out of you, but everyday isn't a race day. Insert "launch day" for "race day" and you'll begin to see the comparison. To be successful on launch/race day you need the foundational rhythm of varied experiences—not monotonous, groundhog days of the same. Days, weeks, and months of flexibility, compromise, tweaks, pivots, sprints, stalls, long hours and rest all meant to make you and your team are ready for launch. Said succinctly:

Training is the work. Race day is the performance.
Building is the work. Launch day is the performance.

Agile vs Waterfall — a technical rabbit trail of sorts.

Let's look at two different styles of planning to see if we can't connect the dots a bit. I want to make sure we all make the jump from analogy to tactical application.

In times past, or maybe in your current work... months are spent on researching a solution, writing requirements, finding funding, drafting an RFP, selecting a vendor, creating 6-month to year-long plans, solidifying funding and organizing teams around said plans.

You do all this pre-work so you can then spend the next three years building the product whose requirements were written two years ago. I say three years, because the amount of change orders, false starts, re-starts, and scope creep have moved a year-long project into three, with the end not yet in sight.

Here is the deal, if you were building a house, bridge, or rocket ship to Mars, these types of delays may be ok, maybe even expected, but in the digital space technology evolves

too quickly for this type of waterfall process. Your competition is not the large behemoth ship to your right and left, with limited turning radius making it difficult to pivot. The competition you should be aware of are versatile like jet ski's – pivoting, testing, launching, disrupting, and innovating their way into your market share. Too many false starts or failed launches and you'll caught by a fresh start twenty-something with a Tesla and bag full of venture capital cash.

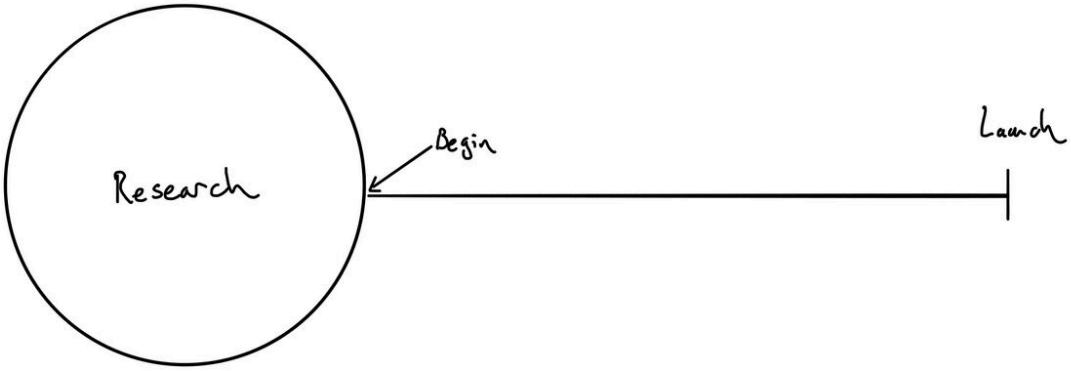
Building digital projects in a waterfall process is like this — if upon realizing I needed to get healthy, spent one-month researching best ways to lose weight, one-month writing requirements for my plan to lose weight, another month to research, interview, and employ a coach, and then next twelve months working through the plan to lose weight. I would be at least two months behind, and more likely 3-4 months behind.

I should just have gotten off the damn couch and started running.

Because it is in the early stages of running — you find the nutrition, the right coach, the right plan, and begin the true work of losing pounds and gaining health. It's not in the planning it's in the running.

It's called analysis paralysis — people spend so much time trying to create plans and new processes for the work, they delay beginning the work. Then by the time they start the work, what they were planning to build is not what will solve the new problem at the door. Some diagrams and explanations will help solidify the point.

Waterfall process:



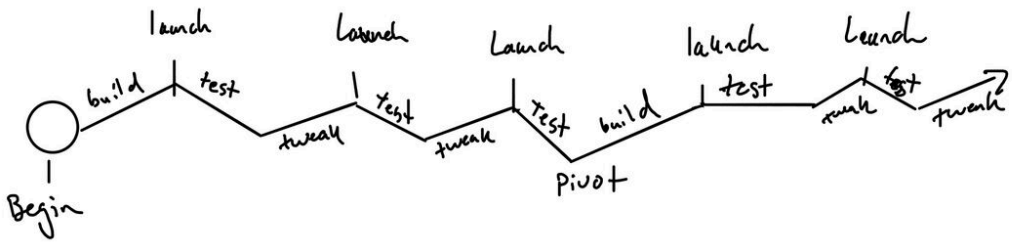
Above is a rather straightforward diagram introducing a waterfall method of development, as the sketch shows, there is a major focus on research, which may include:

- Requirements gathering by a Business Analyst
- Stakeholder interviews by a Business Analyst
- Competitive Review by Product team

- User research by Product team and Customer Insights team
- Project funding estimation by Program Management
- Project Brief by Product and Project Managers
- Project funding approvals by Executive Sponsor
- Project Kickoff!!

Once the research is done the project gets a Project Code and people can start billing time to the project... which means it's officially begun. At many of these kickoff meetings (which can last multiple days), design, operations, training, architecture and development teams are expected to digest all of the requirements and produce a timeline with user stories to meet the deadline set by the executive sponsor. Waterfall is the worst. So, many things out-of-order, with deadlines plucked out of thin air to meet some arbitrary media deadline or earnings call. There is a better way.

Agile Process:



Agile is a framework, started as a manifesto calling teams to work together with a collaborative approach and delivery as the goal. The original framework cited below:

- *Individuals and interactions over processes and tools*
- *Working software over comprehensive documentation*
- *Customer collaboration over contract negotiation*
- *Responding to change over following a plan*
- *That is, while there is value in the items on the right, we value the items on the left more.*[1]

In agile projects is where I've found the most joy in production. Where progress is more important than process — again, not to discount process, but to put it in its prioritized place, a framework where the team building the solution is involved in understanding the solution. This is also a place where lean teams are found, efficiency is rewarded, and delivery is celebrated.

- Program managers build out budgets and chart team velocity.

- Product managers sell in the what and the why and carry the vision.
- Designers test prototypes and conduct research with actual customers.
- Developers build solutions on how to make experience work.
- Architects build continuous integration, delivery, and data models.
- Security consults on best practices and physically tests written code.
- QA engineers find their place alongside the developers, working hand-in-hand editing after the first draft of code has been written.

All of the team members intimately involved in building, testing, and launching their work into the hands of customers! This is where we find engaged teams, passionate individuals, and pleased executives. It is where we find the balance of progress over process.

As we dig into the next few lessons in BEGIN the work, it is important that we start with the right foundation. It is the same in running a marathon — to be ready on race day you have to have the miles under your legs. But as I brought up earlier, it's more about the flexible training plan than the actual miles run.

Much the same in launching a digital product -- to launch any digital product well, which is not to say perfect, you must solidify the what and the why, and have flexibility in achieving the how. Too much reliance on a concrete plan, and you'll deliver what you wanted, but maybe not what the customer needs.

Much of this is a mindset switch for many organizations and especially leaders who have an expectation that it must be near perfect to be in users' hands.

That mindset is certainly important for chicken sandwiches and buildings, but not so much for digital. Success in digital innovation starts with ensuring everyone is logging the miles together, that no one is in their own silo hoarding knowledge unaware of the cross functional work to be done. To begin, is to educate everyone involved in a project, you must bring them along, and they must get their hands dirty with the building — with the doing[2].

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1. More at https://agilemanifesto.org
2. Todd Smith in BEGIN the podcast, Episode 2 talks about the need to break down the barriers between departments, and to ensure that the middle managers and executives don't get out of touch with the doing. Listen here — http://beginthework.com/podcast/todd-smith/